

Cruise Packing Cheat Sheet

Formal nights, shore days, the unpack-once cabin strategy, and the bag-size math — one page.

THE CORE LIST (7-NIGHT WARM-WEATHER SAILING)

Casual tops	5–7
Casual bottoms	2–3
Underwear & socks	5–7 pairs
Swimsuits + cover-up	1–2
Dinner outfits	1–2
Light layer	1 — ship air conditioning is real
Walking shoes	worn · sandals/flip-flops: 1 pair packed
Sunscreen + sunglasses	essential — onboard prices are brutal
Daypack + power bank	1 each, for shore days

FORMAL NIGHTS

- Most lines: 1–2 dressier evenings per 7-night sailing; many are now "smart casual" — check your line before packing a suit.
- 1–2 dinner outfits usually cover it. Dedicated dress shoes are the item that tips people into a checked bag.

SHORE DAYS

- Port days are all-day carries: water, sunscreen, camera, a layer. A small daypack earns its space.
- Back-at-ship rule: whatever you carry off the ship, you carry all day — pack the daypack light.

THE UNPACK-ONCE STRATEGY & BAG-SIZE MATH

- You unpack once into one small cabin — packing cubes keep drawers sane; a toiletry organizer beats a counter you don't have.
- Light packers: 30–35L · Most cruises: 35–45L · Formal-heavy or cold-weather: 45L+ (checked bag is normal — no airline sizer at the pier)
- Carry-on-only (35–40L) works on casual lines for disciplined packers — but many cruisers reasonably check a bag.